

Making Performance Goals SMART

Criteria for Well-Written Goals

For a performance goal to be well written and effective, it needs to meet certain criteria. The acronym SMART is a good way to outline this criteria.

SMART stands for:

- **Specific**—defines specific results to be achieved.
- **Measurable**—defines quantity, cost, or quality metrics to determine progress.
- **Attainable**—allows the goal to be challenging, yet the person can still ensure results.
- **Relevant**—supports the achievement of team or organizational goals.
- **Time bound**—specifies a due date, time frame, or frequency rate.

Tips for Writing SMART Goals

- Start each goal with an action verb (for example, Increase, Complete, Attain).
- Define quantity, cost, timeliness, and/or quality as well as any due dates or time frames.
- Avoid writing “all or nothing” goals. For example, “*Train everyone in the department on the new software system by the end of the third quarter*” is a goal that’s either met or it’s not. Instead, provide flexibility to make the goal more attainable, such as a range: “*Train 95–100 percent of the department . . .*”
- Don’t mistake tasks or activities for performance goals. For example, “*Polling service representatives to find out if they are seeing certain trends in product usage*” is an activity that may be one of many tasks to be completed to achieve a performance goal.
- Make sure each goal is observable. If you are the direct report, the results of your efforts need to be evident to you and others who will provide feedback on performance.
- Limit the number of goals to between one and three for each major output of the job to make the overall performance plan realistic. You always can add or modify as needed.
- If you are the direct report, ask yourself: *Does this goal benefit me, the team, and the organization?* If you are the leader, ask the direct report: *Does this goal benefit you, our team, and the organization?* If not, consider rewriting it.

Formula for Writing SMART Goals

Use this three-part formula to write performance goals that meet the SMART criteria.

Start with an **action verb**
such as:

- Increase . . .
- Complete . . .
- Attain . . .
- Achieve . . .
- Reduce . . .

Include a **measurement**,
such as:

- How much
- How many
- How much better
- How much faster
- Costing how much less

Include a **due date, time
frame, or frequency rate**,
such as:

- Phase 1 by end of second quarter
- End of fiscal year
- Daily
- Weekly
- As scheduled

action verb



measurement



due date



Examples: **Decrease** shipping errors by **3–5 percent** by the **end of the third quarter**.

Achieve an **average minimum rating of 3 on a 5-point scale** in **each quarterly** customer satisfaction audit.

Reduce patient wait time to **20 minutes** by the **end of the fiscal year**.